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Citizen satisfaction with municipal amalgamations

Abstract: When Mike Harris's Conservative government came to power in Ontario, it embarked on a program of significant municipal reform. Municipal amalgamation, one of the major elements of this reform package, had many goals, two of which were "efficient service delivery" and provision of "high-quality services at lowest possible cost." This article reviews three amalgamations, which reduced the number of municipalities from twenty-nine to three, to determine whether the mergers resulted in a change in the quality of service delivery. In all three cases, there was a great outpouring of both positive and negative rhetoric in the lead-up to the amalgamations, but not much happened. There were clearly pockets of dissatisfaction, but most residents did not see a significant change in the quality of services.

Sommaire : Lorsque le gouvernement conservateur de Mike Harris est arrivé au pouvoir en Ontario, il s'est lancé dans un programme de réformes municipales importantes. Le regroupement de municipalités, l'un des principaux éléments de cet ensemble de réformes, avait plusieurs objectifs, dont deux d'entre eux étaient « une prestation efficiente de services » et l'offre de « services de grande qualité au prix le plus bas possible ». Le présent article passe en revue trois regroupements, qui ont réduit le nombre de municipalités de vingt-neuf à trois, pour déterminer si les fusions ont entraîné un changement dans la qualité de la prestation de services. Dans les trois cas, il y a eu une extraordinaire effusion de rhétorique, à la fois positive et négative au cours de la période précédant les regroupements, mais peu se passa. Il y a eu de toute évidence des foyers de mécontentement, mais la plupart des résidents n'ont pas remarqué d'importants changements dans la qualité des services.

When Mike Harris's Conservative government came to power in Ontario, it embarked on a program of significant municipal reform.[1] A major aspect of

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CANADIAN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION / ADMINISTRATION PUBLIQUE DU CANADA
VOLUME 48, NO. 1 (SPRING/PRINTEMPS 2005), PP. 73–95

this reform package, municipal amalgamation, had many goals, two of which were "efficient service delivery" and provision of "high-quality services at the lowest possible cost."[2] This article reviews three amalgamations, which reduced the number of municipalities from twenty-nine to three, to determine whether the mergers resulted in a change in the quality of service delivery.

As in other provinces, the amalgamations were extremely controversial.[3] Those favouring consolidations, such as the provincial government, held that one large government in each metropolitan area would significantly reduce costs without reducing the quality of services. Conversely, public choice advocates, frequently represented by local councillors and local citizens' groups, contended that amalgamation would increase costs, reduce the quality of services, and adversely affect their sense of local community. In virtually every community, discussions about amalgamation generated intense local feelings. For example, in Kent County, an elderly councillor died of a heart attack during the council debates and, in Kingston, city and suburban councillors were so divided that an outside negotiator had to be brought in to bring the two sides closer together.[4]

Much of the debate regarding amalgamations focused on whether the consolidated governments would be more cost effective than multiple governments. Elsewhere, we analyse the changes in levels of expenditures to determine whether or not the Ontario consolidations were cost effective.[5] However, a shortcoming of such studies is that they focus only on changes in the level of expenditures without considering changes in the quantity or quality of services delivered.[6] The provincial government's stated objective in municipal reform was improving efficiency of service delivery, but efficiency is more than merely reducing expenditure. A better, and more widely employed, definition of efficiency is the relationship between inputs and outputs. Efficiency improves when the change in quantity and quality of service provided (outputs) divided by the change in expenditure (inputs) increases.

Inputs can usually be defined and measured fairly easily. Typically, they consist of human resources used and goods and services consumed, measured in dollars. Measuring outputs is more complicated because both quantity and quality must be considered. Measuring the quantity of outputs is easier than measuring quality, because quantity can usually be defined as the objectively measurable change in the service (e.g., the number of kilometres of road, the number of files processed). However, measuring the change in quality is more difficult because subjective judgements are involved. An important measure that goes beyond outputs is *outcomes*. Outcomes are the level of citizen satisfaction with the outputs produced. Outputs and outcomes frequently move in tandem, but not always. For example, construction of a new road would be an output, but if it was constructed in the

wrong place or in a substandard manner, then it might not produce an improvement in outcomes or citizen satisfaction.

Fortunately, there exists a significant literature concerning the measurement of citizens' satisfaction with municipal services.[7] A number of techniques have been used to determine satisfaction, but they all rely on some form of survey to measure how citizens rate municipal services. This is admittedly a subjective judgement made by individuals who have no particular expertise in the services under consideration. Yet, it could easily be argued that citizen satisfaction with services is more important than objective measures of output: "If the role of government is to use its capacity to affect positive change in the quality of life of its citizens, then outcomes are the only useful measure of public accountability."[8] Furthermore, there is some tentative evidence that there is a correlation between objective measures of output and citizens' perceptions of the quality of services.[9]

The proper way to measure efficiency is to focus on inputs, outputs *and* outcomes, although this has seldom been done. One excellent exception is research by James McDavid that analyses the impact of the amalgamation of police services in Halifax through changes in expenditures, as well as changes in objective measures of service and changes in citizens' perceptions of service quality.[10] McDavid's work is similar to earlier work on police services by Elinor Ostrom but more comprehensive in terms of variables used and data on service levels both before and after amalgamation.[11]

This article is part of a larger research project that focuses on three municipalities that were created by amalgamation on 1 January 1998 – Central Elgin, Chatham-Kent and Kingston.[12] These municipalities were chosen because they represent different regions of the province (eastern Ontario [Kingston] and southwestern Ontario [Central Elgin and Chatham-Kent]); different sizes of municipalities (medium-sized with an urban core [Chatham-Kent and Kingston] and smaller, rural [Central Elgin]); and different methods of amalgamation (by voluntary agreements [Central Elgin and Kingston] and by commissioner's order [Chatham-Kent]). Aside from Toronto, Kingston and Chatham-Kent were the second and third largest amalgamations that occurred on that date.

As stated previously, the purpose of this article is to analyse changes in the level of outcomes as measured by the level of public satisfaction with the quality of services before and after amalgamation. Telephone surveys of residents of the amalgamated communities were undertaken in the fall of 2000 and the winter of 2001 – about three years after the amalgamations. Respondents were chosen at random from local telephone directories. The sample size used produced a level of accuracy of plus or minus five percentage points, nineteen times out of twenty.[13] University students trained in interview techniques conducted the surveys. The response rate was approximately seventy per cent.

Ideally, a pre-amalgamation survey should have been conducted to establish a baseline of citizen satisfaction and then to compare the results with a comparable post-amalgamation survey. Unfortunately, the research for this article did not start until after the amalgamations. Instead, respondents were asked how service quality had changed since amalgamation.

The surveys were supplemented with in-depth interviews, conducted on several occasions in 2001 and 2002, of municipal councillors elected in 1998 and with community leaders. The majority of councillors in all municipalities were interviewed. Many of these councillors had served for years on councils in the previous municipalities and were therefore able to provide "before" and "after" comparisons. The community leaders were identified through directories of business, farm and social organizations and by recommendations of other interviewees and elected officials. The interviews were semi-structured, lasted for about an hour, and consisted of a series of open-ended questions.

Central Elgin

The Municipality of Central Elgin (population 11,000) was created by amalgamating Yarmouth Township and the villages of Belmont and Port Stanley. This was part of a broader restructuring in Elgin County that saw the number of municipalities in the county reduced from fifteen to seven and the transfer of some services between the county and the lower-tier municipalities. There was some controversy as a result of this amalgamation, particularly in the Village of Port Stanley, but generally this amalgamation was accomplished more quietly and quickly than the others discussed here.

Survey of citizens

A telephone survey of 542 people (127 respondents from the former Village of Belmont, 147 from the former Village of Port Stanley, and 268 from the former Township of Yarmouth) was conducted over the period 12–27 March 2001.

Respondents were asked to assess the quality of municipal services in two ways. The first involved rating the current quality of eleven services on a scale of 1 (lowest rating) to 5 (highest rating) and the second asked whether the quality of services had changed since amalgamation. Table 1 displays the average rating given to each service by the residents of the three former municipalities. For most services, the responses were sufficiently different to be statistically significant at the .05 level.

Some explanation about the categories is helpful. Even though libraries and seniors homes are county responsibilities, they were included to provide comparability to other municipalities surveyed and to assess if any changes in the quality of county services might have occurred as a result of the broader county restructuring in the creation of Central Elgin.

Table 1. *Citizens' Perception of Current Service Quality in the Municipality of Central Elgin (Rating: 1 = lowest; 5 = highest)*

Type of service	*Belmont*	*Port Stanley*	*Yarmouth*
Roads*	2.88	3.29	3.30
	(n = 126)	(n = 147)	(n = 268)
Snow plowing*	3.69	3.54	3.86
	(n = 126)	(n = 147)	(n = 266)
Parks and playing fields	3.51	3.27	3.17
	(n = 108)	(n = 131)	(n = 222)
Arenas*	3.77	3.82	3.11
	(n = 107)	(n = 131)	(n = 219)
Seniors home*	3.46	3.42	3.18
	(n = 76)	(n = 125)	(n = 199)
Planning and zoning*	2.98	2.72	2.95
	(n = 102)	(n = 127)	(n = 222)
Fire	4.35	4.12	4.24
	(n = 123)	(n = 145)	(n = 258)
Police*	3.06	3.01	3.59
	(n = 121)	(n = 145)	(n = 261)
Library*	4.04	4.17	3.37
	(n = 113)	(n = 138)	(n = 231)
Garbage collection and recycling	3.40	2.97	3.00
	(n = 124)	(n = 147)	(n = 264)
Port Stanley beach*	3.30	3.76	3.32
	(n = 84)	(n = 145)	(n = 239)

n = number of respondents
*Indicates that the difference of averages is statistically significant at the .05 level using a one-way ANOVA test

With the exception of planning, residents seemed fairly satisfied with the quality of services. There were marked differences between the levels of satisfaction in the three former municipalities, but there does not seem to be a pattern; residents of one municipality were not uniformly more satisfied or dissatisfied with all services than were residents of the other municipalities. These results are surprising because other parts of the survey indicated that residents of Port Stanley were considerably more dissatisfied with the amalgamation than were residents of the other municipalities.[14] This general dissatisfaction seems not to have carried over into their assessment of the quality of services provided.

It is important to note that this survey asked respondents to provide their subjective assessment of the quality of a service. Those directly involved in providing services might be able to offer more objective evidence that the quality of the service has changed, as measured by funds spent on the service, quantity of the service provided, or other output measurements. These

measurements might well be more accurate, but outcome measurements as defined by citizens' perceptions are equally important, since citizens are the consumers of public services.

These results can be put into perspective by comparing them to those in other jurisdictions. For example, surveys in other municipalities indicate that the public almost always ranks fire service very highly, while planning, economic development and management of growth generally received relatively low ratings.[15] Firefighters risk their lives for the good of the community, and there is no negative side to firefighting, whereas police also risk their lives, but they also issue traffic tickets. Similar comparisons indicate that planning generally has a low ranking with citizens, which is somewhat surprising, since the average citizen has relatively little direct contact with the planning and zoning function.

[C]itizens generally report no change in the quality of most services in the three years since amalgamation. Residents and the community leaders of the former Village of Port Stanley, however, are the most dissatisfied with the amalgamation, which should not be surprising since this area was the source of the greatest opposition to the amalgamation

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The second component of the survey asked respondents if the quality of services had changed since amalgamation. Tables 2a to 2c indicate that, for virtually every service, the majority of respondents felt that the quality of the service remained unchanged. For many services, the percentage responding in this manner exceeded seventy-five per cent. This finding is not surprising, given the relatively short period of time since the amalgamation. However, it does run contrary to the expectations raised prior to amalgamation that the quality of services would suffer significantly when the smaller jurisdictions were replaced by a larger one. It is also contrary to the expectations of some that there would be a significant improvement in the quality of services. Thus, both extreme views were ill-founded. The perspective of residents is that not much changed after the amalgamation.

As previously mentioned, these are citizens' perceptions rather than objective realities. Although citizens were clearly asked to comment on the *change* in service quality, their answers could be influenced by their general feeling about the quality of the service rather than just the change.

Table 2a reports on responses of residents of the former Village of Belmont. The results are mixed. There is clearly significant dissatisfaction with garbage collection and recycling, and roads, while snowplowing is per-

Table 2a. *Citizens' Perceptions of Changes in Quality of Services in the Belmont Area*

Type of service	*Number of respondents*	*Declined significantly (%)*	*Declined somewhat (%)*	*Stayed the same (%)*	*Improved somewhat (%)*	*Improved significantly (%)*
Roads	123	12.2	19.5	49.6	16.3	2.4
Snowplowing	120	8.3	9.2	50.8	23.3	8.3
Parks and playing fields	104	5.8	6.7	74.0	10.6	2.9
Arenas	101	2.0	5.0	84.2	6.9	2.0
Seniors home	77	1.3	0.0	93.5	5.2	0.0
Planning and zoning	100	8.0	11.0	64.0	16.0	1.0
Fire	120	0.8	3.3	80.0	9.2	6.7
Police	119	4.2	15.1	75.6	3.4	1.7
Library	106	0.8	2.8	81.1	15.1	0.0
Garbage collection and recycling	121	25.6	12.4	51.2	9.9	0.8
Port Stanley beach	81	0.0	3.7	85.2	11.1	0.0

Table 2b. *Citizens' Perceptions of Changes in Quality of Services in the Port Stanley Area*

Type of service	*Number of respondents*	*Declined significantly (%)*	*Declined somewhat (%)*	*Stayed the same (%)*	*Improved somewhat (%)*	*Improved significantly (%)*
Roads	143	9.1	23.8	60.8	5.6	0.7
Snowplowing	141	9.9	26.2	58.2	3.5	2.1
Parks and playing fields	128	7.0	14.8	68.8	9.4	0.0
Arenas	127	0.8	7.1	85.8	5.5	0.8
Seniors home	125	0.8	12.0	86.4	0.0	0.8
Planning and zoning	123	8.9	27.6	52.0	7.3	4.1
Fire	139	0.7	11.5	77.7	7.2	2.9
Police	142	10.6	17.6	62.0	6.3	3.5
Library	136	3.7	9.6	83.1	2.2	1.5
Garbage collection and recycling	143	22.4	27.3	44.8	4.9	0.7
Port Stanley beach	141	2.8	14.9	73.8	5.0	3.5

Table 2c. *Citizens' Perceptions of Changes in Quality of Services in the Yarmouth Area*

Type of service	*Number of respondents*	*Declined significantly (%)*	*Declined somewhat (%)*	*Stayed the same (%)*	*Improved somewhat (%)*	*Improved significantly (%)*
Roads	260	6.9	11.2	65.4	11.2	5.4
Snowplowing	256	3.1	12.9	66.8	12.5	4.7
Parks and playing fields	223	1.8	6.7	83.0	6.7	1.8
Arenas	215	0.9	6.5	89.3	3.3	0.0
Seniors home	202	1.5	5.9	88.6	4.0	0.0
Planning and zoning	222	5.4	11.7	73.9	7.2	1.8
Fire	252	0.8	2.0	79.8	11.1	6.3
Police	256	4.7	6.6	78.9	8.2	1.6
Library	229	0.9	9.6	84.3	3.9	1.3
Garbage collection and recycling	261	23.4	20.3	49.0	6.1	1.1
Port Stanley beach	229	3.9	6.6	80.3	7.0	2.2

Table 3. *Citizens' Perception of Value for Taxes in the Municipality of Central Elgin*

Area	*Number of respondents*	*Better (%)*	*Same (%)*	*Worse (%)*
Belmont	125	7.2	45.6	47.2
Port Stanley	141	9.2	23.4	67.4
Yarmouth	258	5.4	44.2	50.4

ceived to have improved considerably since amalgamation. For most other services, there have been few changes in quality.

Table 2b indicates that residents of the former Port Stanley area see more reductions than improvements in the quality of services, especially in garbage collection and recycling, planning, roads and snowplowing. Only a very small number of people saw an improvement in the quality of services.

The views of residents of the former Yarmouth Township, as illustrated in Table 2c, were less extreme than those of the residents of the former Port Stanley. But, again, a significant number of respondents saw a reduction in the quality of garbage collection and recycling services. The negative views are the result of a specific, short-term problem. At the time of this survey, the municipality was in a serious dispute with its garbage collection contractor. The contract was ultimately terminated and a new contractor was found.[16] Later interviews with community leaders indicated that garbage collection improved considerably.

Table 3 summarizes responses to the question "Comparing the situation before and after amalgamation on January 1, 1998, is the value that you are receiving for your taxes now better, the same, or worse than it was before the creation of the Municipality of Central Elgin?" Few people in any jurisdiction were willing to admit that the value for taxes paid had increased. In Belmont and Yarmouth, respondents were about evenly divided between perceiving no change and lower value, while residents of Port Stanley were most likely to say that value for taxes had declined.

Interviews with councillors and other community leaders

To supplement these broad-based telephone interviews and to obtain a deeper understanding of attitudes expressed in the surveys, twenty interviews were conducted with twenty-one community leaders in the Central Elgin area (Table 4), as well as with the majority of councillors in all three municipalities.

This classification somewhat understates the diversity of interests canvassed in the interviews. For example, people classified as "regional," because their organization covered the entire area, lived in one particular

Table 4. *Interviews with Community Leaders in Central Elgin*

Previous municipality		*Type of organization*		*Gender*	
Belmont	2	Agriculture and fishing	3	Female	7
Port Stanley	6	Business	7	Male	14
Yarmouth	2	Residents' and service clubs	4		
Regional	10	Recreation and youth	4		
		Social service	2		
Total	20		20		21

Number of people interviewed does not agree with number of interviews because there was more than one person present at some interviews

jurisdiction and often commented on that particular area in addition to the new unit. Also, community leaders had diverse interests; for example, leaders in business organizations were also frequently active in sports or social-service agencies. Interviewees were classified according to the category of their major interest.

The views expressed tended to support those of the broader community survey, as well as the negative feelings in Port Stanley. Community leaders in this area spoke strongly about the impact of removing municipal council from the centre of the village to the county building in the former Yarmouth Township and of the difficulty of getting to the new location. The fact that the new municipal office is about a ten-minute drive from Port Stanley suggests that the divide is more psychological than geographical, but it is still seen as a significant divide by the local residents.

The general levels of satisfaction are as surprising in Chatham-Kent as they were in Central Elgin

When asked questions about specific services, leaders were generally quite positive, even those who had expressed negative views about the amalgamation. Thus, grievances, while real, seem to relate more to intangible ideas or attitudes rather than to more tangible issues such as snowplowing or road maintenance.

In summary, citizens generally report no change in the quality of most services in the three years since amalgamation.[17] Residents and the community leaders of the former Village of Port Stanley, however, are the most dissatisfied with the amalgamation, which should not be surprising since this area was the source of the greatest opposition to the amalgamation.

Chatham-Kent

The Municipality of Chatham-Kent (population 110,000) was created by

amalgamating the City of Chatham and Kent County and its twenty-one constituent municipalities. This amalgamation generated a great deal of controversy because there were long-standing negative feelings between the City of Chatham (which was separated from the county) and the county (which completely surrounded the city). Over a two-year period before amalgamation, there were numerous proposals for restructuring the county by combining some of its constituent municipalities. Most of these proposals left the City of Chatham as a distinct city. When the various stakeholders could not agree on a restructuring proposal, the province responded to the requests of several municipalities by appointing a commissioner. The commissioner ordered a complete consolidation of Kent County, its twenty-one municipalities, and the City of Chatham. While many alternatives had been on the table before the arrival of the commissioner, none of them had seriously considered such a complete change in the status quo. The fact that this was such a radical restructuring, combined with its imposition by an outsider, meant that opposition to this amalgamation was much greater than that in Central Elgin.

Survey of citizens

A telephone survey of 395 people was conducted over the period 20 September–11 October 2000. Because of the large number of amalgamated municipalities, no attempt was made to provide separate samples of the constituent areas, as was done in the other two amalgamated municipalities. Unfortunately, this information could not be collected because the size of the sample needed to report on twenty-two different jurisdictions was prohibitive.

Table 5 displays the average rating given by respondents for each municipal service. Residents seem to be reasonably satisfied with most services except roadside grass cutting and drainage in the rural areas, public transit in the urban area, and planning and zoning generally.

The second component of the survey asked respondents if the quality of services had changed since amalgamation. Table 6 indicates that for every service, except policing and roadside grass cutting, the majority of respondents felt that the quality of the service had remained unchanged. For policing, there was roughly an even division between those who felt the service had improved and those who felt it had declined. Only roadside grass cutting attracted a strong negative feeling.

The general levels of satisfaction are as surprising in Chatham-Kent as they were in Central Elgin. The dispute over amalgamation was considerably more intense in Chatham-Kent than in the other two amalgamated municipalities, so the dire predictions and rosy promises from the opposing sides were even stronger here, and, yet, as with Central Elgin, there was a general feeling that not much had changed in terms of quality of service.

Table 7 summarizes responses to the question "Comparing the situation before and after amalgamation on January 1, 1998, is the value that you are

Table 5. *Citizens' Perception of Current Service Quality in the Municipality of Chatham-Kent (Rating: 1 = lowest; 5 = highest*

Type of service	*Number of respondents*	*Average response*
Roads	385	3.20
Snow plowing	380	3.14
Parks and playing fields	303	3.19
Recreational programs	293	3.19
Arenas	293	3.34
Seniors homes	287	3.62
Planning and zoning	279	2.94
Public transit (former city only)	113	2.95
Drainage (rural areas only)	219	2.90
Fire	374	3.99
Police	381	3.48
Library	341	3.86
Garbage collection and recycling	343	3.73
Swimming pools	264	3.36
Roadside grass cutting (rural areas only)	230	2.72

receiving for your taxes now better, the same, or worse than it was before the creation of the Municipality of Chatham-Kent?" The responses in Chatham-Kent were slightly more positive than those in Central Elgin, although only a small minority (thirteen per cent) felt that they were receiving better value for their taxes as a result of amalgamation.

Interviews with councillors and other community leaders

Twenty-two interviews were conducted with twenty-seven community leaders in Chatham-Kent (Table 8). These individuals were identified in the same manner as those in Central Elgin.

This classification to some extent understates the diversity of interests represented in the interviews. For example, Chatham might seem underrepresented, but many of the people identified as "regional" either lived in Chatham or their organization served the entire region from a central office in Chatham. As in Central Elgin, community leaders tended to have diverse interests but they were classified by their main area of interest.

The views expressed by community leaders were consistent with those of the broader community. Few leaders reported that amalgamation had a major impact on the activities of their organizations. Many organizations already served the entire Chatham and Kent County area or some large part of it, so that a municipal amalgamation within their territory had little impact. Leaders of social service agencies frequently stated that they dealt

Table 6. *Citizens' Perceptions of Changes in Quality of Services in the Municipality of Chatham-Kent*

Type of service	*Number of respondents*	*Declined significantly (%)*	*Declined somewhat (%)*	*Stayed the same (%)*	*Improved somewhat (%)*	*Improved significantly (%)*
Roads	385	8.6	14.3	51.4	20.2	5.4
Snow plowing	380	11.3	20.3	50.3	12.1	6.0
Parks and playing fields	303	10.2	12.9	61.1	11.9	3.9
Recreational programs	293	4.0	14.0	62.1	17.4	2.4
Arenas	293	4.7	10.5	69.1	13.6	2.0
Seniors homes	287	3.9	7.3	64.4	18.8	5.6
Planning and zoning	279	9.6	15.4	55.5	17.6	1.8
Public transit (former city only)	113	7.0	8.7	78.0	6.3	0.0
Drainage (rural areas only)	219	19.1	14.6	55.2	9.6	1.4
Fire	374	3.7	7.5	61.0	20.6	7.2
Police	381	12.9	20.3	36.1	20.5	10.3
Library	341	2.3	6.1	55.5	23.2	12.9
Garbage pickup and recycling	343	4.7	9.9	67.3	12.2	5.9
Swimming pools	264	4.2	8.4	76.1	8.4	3.0
Roadside grass cutting (rural areas only)	230	17.8	24.4	47.7	8.7	1.4

Table 7. *Citizens' Perception of Value for Taxes in the Municipality of Chatham-Kent*

Number of respondents	*Better (%)*	*Same (%)*	*Worse (%)*
369	13.3	39.0	47.7

Table 8. *Interviews with Community Leaders in Chatham-Kent*

Electoral ward		*Type of organization*		*Gender*	
West Kent	3	Agriculture and fishing	6	Female	13
South Kent	1	Business	6	Male	14
East Kent	2	Residents' and service clubs	4		
North Kent	3	Recreation and youth	1		
Chatham	1	Social service	5		
Wallaceburg	3				
Regional	9				
Total	22		22		27

Number of people interviewed does not agree with number of interviews because there was more than one person present at some interviews.

directly with individual clients and received their funding from some combination of provincial government and the United Way. Therefore, municipal amalgamations had little impact on them.

The interviews reflected the long-standing division between the former City of Chatham and the areas in the former Kent County, in spite of the efforts of municipal staff, politicians and community leaders to attenuate these differences.[18] In some ways, this could be seen as a rural-urban split, but there are a number of smaller urban areas outside Chatham that seem to share a certain aloofness from Chatham.

There were conscious attempts to bridge this gulf through efforts such as the establishment of the Chatham-Kent Agribusiness Advisory Committee shortly after amalgamation[19] and the annual "Opportunity Tour," which is a bus tour of the entire region organized by this committee and the Agriculture Committee of the Chatham and District Chamber of Commerce. This opportunity for politicians and staff to visit areas of interest throughout the entire new municipality was well received, but organizers commented that some councillors from the former city never found time to take part in this activity. Some of those interviewed suggested that urban-dwellers were now more interested in attending some of the agricultural fairs and similar events. It was clear from discussions that the rural-based agricultural events have continued to prosper within the new mixed rural-urban municipality.

As frequently happens in municipal issues, both sides felt aggrieved by certain issues. Those outside Chatham felt that city-dwellers did not under-

stand some uniquely rural problems, such as farm drainage, whereas city-dwellers were concerned that rural areas were favoured in the political process. A number of councillors from rural areas commented (pointedly, off the record) that some major public-works improvements in their areas were now funded by the new larger municipality, not just by the residents in the immediate area. Councillors from urban areas were aware of this kind of thinking and viewed it derogatorily as a "county way" of thinking.

In summary, as in Central Elgin, leaders in all areas were generally quite positive about levels of service provision, even those who had expressed negative views about the amalgamation. Again, grievances relate more to intangible attitudes than to more tangible issues. Also, as in Central Elgin, citizens generally reported seeing no change in the quality of most services in the three years since the amalgamation.

Kingston

The new City of Kingston (population 111,000) was created by amalgamating the former City of Kingston and the townships of Kingston and Pittsburgh. As in Chatham-Kent, there had been long-standing animosities between the various jurisdictions. Taxes were considerably higher in the city than in the surrounding townships, due, the city said, to its subsidizing of the townships. Conversely, the townships viewed the city's higher taxes as a sign of inefficiency and poor management. The city was generally in favour of amalgamation because its subsidization of the townships would end, while the townships were opposed to amalgamation because they feared that their taxes would rise.

The differences between the city and the townships are quite marked. Over half of city residents felt that their value for taxes was the same or better, while residents in the townships felt that the value was considerably worse

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The amalgamation occurred through a voluntary agreement among the three jurisdictions. However, some would question the use of the word "voluntary," because the participants in the Kingston process were aware that a commissioner could be appointed to impose a solution. Thus, they were fearful that if they did not arrive at a "voluntary" agreement, they would lose control of the process.

Survey of citizens

A telephone survey of 582 people (212 were from the former City of Kingston, 207 from the former Township of Kingston, and 163 from the former

Table 9. *Citizens' Perception of Current Service Quality in the City of Kingston (Rating: 1 = lowest; 5 = highest)*

Type of service	*City of Kingston*	*Kingston Township*	*Pittsburgh Township*
Roads*	2.51 (n = 212)	2.96 (n = 205)	3.25 (n = 163)
Snow plowing*	3.21 (n = 211)	3.07 (n = 206)	3.51 (n = 162)
Parks and playing fields*	3.60 (n = 184)	3.44 (n = 173)	3.27 (n = 140)
Recreational programs*	3.58 (n = 167)	3.46 (n = 167)	3.09 (n = 122)
Arenas*	3.16 (n = 167)	3.33 (n = 149)	2.51 (n = 116)
Rideaucrest Home for Seniors	3.97 (n = 121)	3.87 (n = 94)	3.77 (n = 75)
Planning and zoning	2.72 (n = 160)	2.92 (n = 167)	2.67 (n = 122)
Public transit*	3.09 (n = 182)	2.74 (n = 155)	2.52 (n = 135)
Fire*	4.10 (n = 186)	3.69 (n = 182)	4.01 (n = 150)
Police*	3.99 (n = 203)	3.59 (n = 197)	3.76 (n = 152)
Library	4.08 (n = 194)	3.93 (n = 187)	4.14 (n = 155)
Cultural activities such as the Grand Theatre	3.92 (n = 194)	3.82 (n = 184)	3.72 (n = 142)
Garbage collection and recycling	3.77 (n = 210)	3.93 (n = 203)	3.93 (n = 162)
Swimming pools*	3.08 (n = 150)	2.78 (n = 135)	2.93 (n = 115)

n = number of respondents
*Indicates that the difference of averages is statistically significant at the .05 level using a one-way ANOVA test

Township of Pittsburgh) was conducted over the period 26 February–19 March 2001.

Table 9 displays the average rating given to each municipal service by the residents of the three former municipalities.

It is very difficult to find any pattern in attitudes towards the quality of municipal services. The townships were the source of the greatest dissatisfaction about the amalgamation, but that dissatisfaction is not reflected in the attitudes to services. For example, city residents were most dissatisfied with roads but were most pleased with police. Residents of Pittsburgh were not happy with public transit but they were very pleased with the quality of the

library. Citizens' general dissatisfaction in Kingston with amalgamation is similar to that expressed in the other municipalities in that it has not carried over into their assessment of the quality of individual services provided.

The second component of the survey asked respondents if the quality of services had changed since amalgamation. Tables 10a to 10c indicate that for virtually every service, the majority of respondents felt that the quality of the service remained unchanged. For many services, the percentage responding in this manner exceeded seventy-five per cent.

This finding is not surprising, given the relatively short period of time since the amalgamation. However, it does run contrary to the expectations raised prior to amalgamation that the quality of services would either suffer significantly when the smaller jurisdictions were replaced by one larger one or improve. Neither extreme was borne out. The perspective of residents is that not much changed after the amalgamation.

There were clearly pockets of dissatisfaction, but most residents did not see a significant change in the quality of services

Table 11 summarizes responses to the question "Comparing the situation before and after amalgamation on January 1, 1998, is the value that you are receiving for your taxes now better, the same, or worse than it was before the creation of the new City of Kingston?" The differences between the city and the townships are quite marked. Over half of city residents felt that their value for taxes was the same or better, while residents in the townships felt that the value was considerably worse. This might seem surprising, given the responses in tables 10a to 10c that the quality of services had not declined. However, the residents of the townships were likely responding to the fact that their taxes had increased after the amalgamation. It is difficult to determine how much of this increase resulted from the amalgamation and how much from the property reassessment that coincidentally occurred at the same time, but it was clear that many residents were unhappy and that they blamed the change on the amalgamation.

Interviews with councillors and other community leaders

To supplement these broad-based telephone interviews, twenty-seven interviews were conducted with thirty-one community leaders in Kingston (Table 12). The views expressed by community leaders tended to support those in the broader community survey. Few leaders suggested that the amalgamation had a major impact on their activities. Many organizations already served all of the new area, or some fairly large portion of it, so that

Table 10a. *Citizens' Perceptions of Changes in Quality of Services in the City of Kingston Area*

Type of service	*Number of respondents*	*Declined significantly (%)*	*Declined somewhat (%)*	*Stayed the same (%)*	*Improved somewhat (%)*	*Improved significantly (%)*
Roads	199	9.5	14.6	59.8	12.6	3.5
Snowplowing	200	7.5	14.5	54.0	16.5	7.5
Parks and playing fields	170	2.9	8.2	80.0	6.5	2.4
Recreation	158	3.2	6.3	73.4	14.6	2.5
Arenas	154	8.4	9.1	73.4	6.5	2.6
Rideaucrest Home for Seniors	121	3.3	1.7	81.0	8.3	5.8
Planning and zoning	152	14.5	12.5	63.2	8.6	1.3
Public transit	173	6.9	10.4	71.1	8.7	2.9
Fire	177	1.7	6.2	72.4	11.9	2.8
Police	189	3.7	10.1	69.3	12.2	4.8
Library	179	1.7	6.1	72.1	12.8	7.3
Culture	183	1.6	5.5	81.4	8.7	2.7
Garbage	196	2.6	10.2	75.5	8.7	3.1
Swimming pools	145	4.1	11.7	79.3	2.8	2.1

Table 10b. *Citizens' Perceptions of Changes in Quality of Services in the Kingston Township Area*

Type of service	*Number of respondents*	*Declined significantly (%)*	*Declined somewhat (%)*	*Stayed the same (%)*	*Improved somewhat (%)*	*Improved significantly (%)*
Roads	203	11.8	23.2	58.1	4.9	2.0
Snowplowing	202	22.3	20.8	47.0	6.9	3.0
Parks and playing fields	169	4.7	11.2	76.9	5.3	1.8
Recreation	160	1.9	11.3	78.8	5.6	2.5
Arenas	149	4.7	10.1	78.5	4.0	2.7
Rideaucrest Home of Seniors	107	3.7	1.9	82.2	7.5	4.7
Planning and zoning	156	11.5	17.3	63.5	6.4	1.3
Public transit	155	4.5	11.0	79.4	4.5	0.6
Fire	179	2.8	12.8	71.5	11.7	1.1
Police	190	5.8	13.7	60.5	15.8	4.2
Library	179	2.8	3.4	74.3	13.4	6.1
Culture	179	0.6	2.8	87.2	7.8	1.7
Garbage	196	4.6	8.2	80.1	5.1	2.0
Swimming pools	135	3.7	6.7	83.7	5.9	0.0

Table 10c. *Citizens' Perceptions of Changes in Quality of Services in the Pittsburgh Township Area*

Type of service	*Number of respondents*	*Declined significantly (%)*	*Declined somewhat (%)*	*Stayed the same (%)*	*Improved somewhat (%)*	*Improved significantly (%)*
Roads	159	V8.2	22.0	64.2	4.4	0.6
Snowplowing	158	15.8	17.7	55.1	5.7	5.1
Parks and playing fields	140	3.6	8.6	79.3	7.9	0
Recreation	123	2.4	8.9	78.0	8.2	1.6
Arenas	112	3.6	3.6	83.9	6.3	1.8
Rideaucrest Home of Seniors	78	1.3	6.4	84.6	3.9	2.6
Planning and zoning	119	16.0	27.7	49.6	5.1	0.8
Public transit	129	3.1	4.7	79.1	10.9	1.6
Fire	145	0.7	5.5	89.0	3.5	0.7
Police	146	6.2	11.0	55.5	20.7	6.2
Library	153	0.0	2.0	56.2	19.6	22.2
Culture	142	0.7	4.9	84.5	7.8	1.4
Garbage	159	2.5	7.5	83.0	5.7	0.6
Swimming pools	112	2.7	4.5	85.7	3.6	2.7

Table 11. *Citizens' Perception of Value for Taxes in the City of Kingston*

Area	*Number of respondents*	*Better (%)*	*Same (%)*	*Worse (%)*
City	178	9.0	52.2	38.8
Township	189	3.7	38.6	57.7
Pittsburgh	156	6.4	25.0	68.6

Table 12. *Interviews with Community Leaders in Kingston*

Area		*Type of organization*		*Gender*	
City	6	Agriculture and fishing	1	Female	11
Pittsburgh	4	Business	6	Male	20
Township	3	Residents' and service clubs	8		
Regional	14	Recreation and youth	4		
		Social service	6		
		Labour	1		
		Other	1		
Total	27		27		31

Number of people interviewed does not agree with number of interviews because there was more than one person present at some interviews.

municipal amalgamation within their territory had little impact. Leaders of social-service agencies often reported that they dealt directly with individual clients and received funding from some combination of the provincial government and the United Way. As a result, municipal amalgamations had little effect on them. Thus, as in Central Elgin and Chatham-Kent, both the residents and community leaders of Kingston generally reported no change in the quality of most services in the three years since the amalgamation.

Conclusion

The title for Shakespeare's play, *Much Ado about Nothing*, best describes the amalgamations. This finding is similar to that by Wim Derksen in his study of several European jurisdictions.[20] In all three cases analysed in this article, there was a great outpouring of both positive and negative rhetoric in the lead-up to amalgamation. The provincial government and others who supported amalgamations promised significant cost-savings and efficiency improvements, whereas opponents predicted chaos and great citizen dissatisfaction resulting from the loss of the smaller units of local government. However, judged by citizens' perceptions of the quality of service, not much happened. There were clearly pockets of dissatisfaction, but most residents did not see a significant change in the quality of services.

Notes

1 Terrence J. Downey and Robert J. Williams, "Provincial agendas, local responses: The "common sense" restructuring of Ontario's municipal governments," CANADIAN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION 41, no. 2 (Summer 1998), pp. 210–38; Katherine A. Graham and Susan D. Phillips, "'Who does what' in Ontario: The process of provincial-municipal disentanglement," in Ibid., pp. 175–209; Robert J. Williams and Terrence J. Downey, "Reforming rural Ontario," CANADIAN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION 42, no. 2 (Summer 1999), pp. 160–92.

2 Ontario, Ministry of Municipal Affairs and Housing, *A Guide to Municipal Restructuring* (Toronto: Queen's Printer, 1996), pp. ii–iii.

3 Andrew Sancton, "Metropolitan and Regional Governance," in Edmund P. Fowler and David Siegel, eds., *Urban Policy Issues: Canadian Perspectives*, 2nd edition (Don Mills, Ont.: Oxford University Press Canada, 2002), pp. 55–7.

4 Thomas R. Hollick and David Siegel, *Evolution, Revolution, Amalgamation: Restructuring in Three Ontario Municipalities* (London, Ont.: Local Government Program, Department of Political Science, University of Western Ontario, 2001).

5 Joseph Kushner and David Siegel, "Are services delivered more efficiently after municipal amalgamations?" CANADIAN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION, forthcoming.

6 George Boyne, "Local government structure and performance: Lessons from America," *Public Administration* 70, no. 3 (Autumn 1992), pp. 333–57.

7 Dale H. Poel, "Amalgamation perspectives: Citizen responses to municipal consolidation," *Canadian Journal of Regional Science* 23, no. 1 (Spring 2000), pp. 31–48; Hari Das, Mallika Das and Francis McKenzie, "Assessing the 'will of the people': An investigation into town service delivery satisfaction," CANADIAN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION 38, no. 1 (Spring 1995), pp. 77–93; David Swindell and Janet M. Kelly, "Linking citizen satisfaction data to performance measures: A preliminary examination," *Public Performance and Management Review* 24, no. 1 (September 2000), pp. 30–52; Janet M. Kelly and David Swindell, "A multiple-indicator approach to municipal service evaluation: Correlating performance measurement and citizen satisfaction across jurisdictions," *Public Administration Review* 62, no. 5 (September/October 2002), pp. 610–22.

8 Janet M. Kelly and David Swindell, "Service quality variation across urban space: First steps toward a model of citizen satisfaction," *Journal of Urban Affairs* 24, no. 3 (2002), p. 273.

9 Swindell and Kelly, "Linking satisfaction data to performance measures," *Public Performance and Management Review.*

10 James C. McDavid, "The impact of amalgamation on police services in the Halifax Regional Municipality," CANADIAN PUBLIC ADMINISTRATION 45, no. 2 (Winter 2002), pp. 538–65.

11 Elinor Ostrom, "The need for multiple indicators in measuring the output of public agencies," *Policy Studies Journal* 2, no. 2 (Winter 1973), pp. 85–92.

12 For a more complete story about how these amalgamations came about, see Hollick and Siegel, *Evolution, Revolution, Amalgamation.*

13 A full copy of the questionnaire can be obtained from the authors.

14 Joseph Kushner and David Siegel, "Citizens' attitudes toward municipal amalgamation in three Ontario municipalities," *Canadian Journal of Regional Science* 26, no. 1 (Spring 2003), pp. 49–59.

15 Thomas I. Miller and Michelle A. Miller, *Citizen Surveys: How to Do Them, How to Use Them, What They Mean* (Washington, D.C.: International City Management Association, 1991), pp. 107–17 and Appendix D.

16 [n.a.], "Riled over garbage run in Central Elgin," *Times-Journal* (St. Thomas), 11 January 2000; [n.a.], "C.E. terminates TCR," *Times-Journal* (St. Thomas), 5 March 2001.

17 The "no change" finding is similar to that found in Poel, "Amalgamation perspectives," *Canadian Journal of Regional Science*, p. 38.

18 The impact of this on the amalgamation process is described in Hollick and Siegel, *Evolution, Revolution, Amalgamation.*

19 [n.a.], "Farmers form C-K Advisory Committee," *Chatham Daily News*, 17 March 1998; Heather Kok Wright, "Committee hopes to smooth over farmer, non-farmer differences," *Chatham Daily News*, 21 April 1998.

20 Wim Derksen, "Municipal amalgamations and the doubtful relation between size and performance," *Local Government Studies* 14, no. 6 (November/December 1988), pp. 31–47.